sentries patrol back and forth and see each other. Do you consider, then, that you have the right to demand security for your own country and the removal of the weapons you call offensive, but do not accord the same right to us? You have placed destructive missile weapons, which you call offensive, in Turkey, literally next to us. How then can recognition of our equal military capacities be reconciled with such unequal relations between our great states? This is irreconcilable."

Khrushchev's offer read as follows: "We are willing to remove from Cuba the means that you regard as offensive. We are willing to carry this out and to make this pledge in the United Nations. Your representatives will make a declaration to the effect that the United States, for its part, considering the uneasiness and anxiety of the Soviet State, will remove its analogous means from Turkey." Khrushchev further proposed that the Soviet Union give a pledge at the UN Security Council to respect the independence and territorial integrity of Turkey, and that the United States give a similar pledge with regard to Cuba. He promised a bright future in Soviet-American relations if only the deal on Cuba and Turkey could be reached. That future included the signing of the nuclear test-ban treaty that was so dear to Kennedy's heart. The two deals could be negotiated and approved simultaneously, which could mean only one thing: Khrushchev was prepared to throw in concessions on the test-ban agreement in order to push through the Cuba-Turkey missile swap.[18]

Khrushchev gambled on Kennedy's reluctance to attack Cuba, but he had no guarantee that such an attack might not come soon. Accordingly, it was imperative to deliver the letter to the White House at top speed, ideally not only before a possible attack on the island but also before Kennedy responded to Khrushchev's offer of the previous day, which made no mention of Turkey and proposed only to remove Soviet "specialists" in exchange for an American pledge not to invade Cuba. He knew that it would take hours, perhaps a whole day for the letter to be delivered, translated, and then telegraphed in sections to Washington from the US embassy in Moscow. The new letter was significantly shorter than his previous one but still amounted to 1,575 words in English. The Presidium decided to broadcast the letter on Soviet radio as soon as possible.[19]